



INDIA'S BRONZE MEDAL WINNERS STOOD ON THE ROADSIDE GIVING INTERVIEWS AS THE IOA'S MEDIA IN-CHARGE COULD NOT HOLD AN ORDERLY PRESS CONFERENCE.



AP PHOTO/RICK BOWMER



MEDAL OF HOPE:
Vijender Singh
(right) shows his
middleweight boxing
bronze medal

where India have excelled. All that aspiring shuttlers need is a basic court within 20 minutes of a neighbourhood cluster and a coach who can teach them correct technique. China has mass sports facilities; every possible open space is kitted out with an outdoor gym that gives the common public a chance to get exercise. India fails its athletes in the details: Olympic bronze medallist Sushil Kumar said the only luxury that wrestlers, brought up in *akhara*s, wanted was high-quality sports medicine back-up.

FIND THE BEST COACHES

It is what the Chinese have done hiring as many as 38 foreign coaches and paying them top dollar. Indian sports federations hire second rung, cut-price foreign coaches from the old Soviet states because of unreasonable and outdated Sports Ministry stipulations about salary ceilings. Or alternatively, they stick with a tired retinue of

national coaches, who keep their jobs regardless of their medal turnover at the level where it really counts—the Asian Games and the Olympics.

Elite athletes constantly need new voices in their ear. The current boxing coach Gurbaksh Singh Sandhu is a veteran of four Olympics with excellent people skills, an ideal candidate today for a new role of boxing squad manager. Younger coaches like C. Kuttappa, Jaidev Bisht and Ramanand, all of whom worked hard with the Beijing squad, now need to join the squad with an eye on the London Olympics.

Similarly, India's best homegrown coaches must encourage their most-gifted charges to fly higher. Many of our best sportsmen and women stagnate because their coaches do not let go. India has excellent development coaches but the jump into global contention comes only with the help of a performance coach. World champions are the products of the combined work of development and performance coaches: neither can perform the job of

the other. Marc Labuschagne, former national track and field sprint coach for South Africa, took one look at Indian 4x400m runner M.R. Poovama and said if he could be given five more runners of her quality to work with for four years, India could expect Olympic medals in London.

India has plenty of talent but it has failed to push them down on the road to cover the last mile of excellence.

RESPECT THE ATHLETE

At the Beijing opening ceremony, the Indian Olympic squad team looked like they couldn't rustle up a common ceremonial uniform between them, their training gear came from a distinctly second-rate sportswear designer based in east Delhi, India's bronze medal winners stood on the roadside giving interviews because the Indian Olympic Association's (IOA) media in-charge could not be bothered to hold an orderly, dignified press conference for them. Athletes' guest passes into the Games Village were squirrelled away by delegation officials who handed them out to visiting dignitaries from Delhi, nobody from the IOA bothered to turn up at Vijender's medal ceremony and the sports minister failed to recognise India's greatest badminton player after Prakash Padukone. But take a look at the photos that feature the medallist meeting with the high and mighty on their return to Delhi. The officials, including the omnipresent IOA chief Suresh Kalmadi, are positioned dead centre.

It is where officials believe they, and not the athlete, really belong. Most believe in sport as a tool to power, that Indian sport exists to serve their ambitions and not the other way around. The moment an athlete succeeds, he takes away the officials' spotlight. That is why some are content to let Indian sport remain mediocre. They are a very big reason why we are. ■